

A FREE TOOL FOR ARTISTS

Artist Statement Tool

A question sequence you hand to Claude (or ChatGPT). It talks you through finding the throughline in your work, one stage at a time, until you have a draft you can actually use.

FILES NEEDED

github.com/rucyl-mills/artist-statement-tool

WEBPAGE

rucyl.com/artist-statement-tool

WHAT THIS IS

A worksheet that Claude runs for you

This isn't a form to fill in on your own. It's a set of instructions, written to Claude, telling it how to interview you about your practice, question by question, and then draft your statement from what you say. You do the talking. Claude does the assembling.

It exists because most artists get stuck at the same point: not the sentences, but figuring out what actually holds the work together across years and bodies of work. That's the part this tool is built to dig out first, before any drafting happens.

How it was built

- **Read against a real application.** The question sequence was built by reviewing the official 2027 application guide for the Guggenheim Fellowship, one of the most respected mid-career grants going, to see exactly what a serious funder asks for: a Career Narrative (who you are, how the work has moved) and a Statement of Plans (what you want to do next, and why it matters, in a fundable timeframe).
- **Checked against what actually works.** Alongside the application guide, this drew on writing about strong artist statements and fellowship essays, including a widely read Guggenheim-winning career narrative that opens on a single object rather than a résumé. The pattern that kept showing up: specificity beats summary, and a throughline is a question, not a subject.
- **Turned into a conversation, not a checklist.** The questions are written so Claude asks them in order, pushes past clichés for concrete detail, and doesn't let you skip the hard part (finding the throughline) to get to the easy part (listing accomplishments).

Two versions are included. One is written with the Guggenheim's actual two-document structure in mind (Career Narrative and Statement of Plans, 1,000 words each) as a concrete example of what a top-tier application looks like. The other is a general version for any grant, residency or open call, that asks what the specific application requires before it drafts. Use whichever matches what you're applying for; the questions that matter most, Stage 1, are identical in both.

BEFORE YOU START

Get a free account

You need somewhere to upload the file and have a conversation. Either of these works, and both have a free version with no credit card required.

Claude (recommended)

- Go to **claude.ai** in a browser.
- Click **Sign up** and use your email or Google account.
- Verify your email if asked.
- You'll land in a chat window. That's it, no setup, no extra settings to change.

Recommended because this tool was written and tested for Claude, and the free plan handles a file upload and a long conversation comfortably.

ChatGPT (also fine)

- Go to **chatgpt.com** in a browser.
- Click **Sign up** and use your email or Google account.
- Verify your email if asked.
- Use the free plan; no paid tier is required for this.

Since the tool is just a plain text file, ChatGPT can read and follow it the same way. If one gives you trouble, try the other.

You only need to do this once. After that, it's just opening a browser tab and starting a new chat whenever you want to work on the statement.

STEP BY STEP

How to use the file

1

Start a brand new chat

Not a chat you've used before for something else. A fresh conversation, so Claude (or ChatGPT) reads the tool file cold, with no other context steering it.

2

Upload the .md file

Use the attach or upload button in the chat box and select the tool file (see the filenames on the next page). It's a plain text file, nothing to install or convert first.

3

Say "walk me through this"

Or anything similar. Claude will read the instructions in the file and start with the first question. You don't need to explain what the file is; it already knows.

4

Answer one question at a time, honestly

Take your time on the early questions especially. They're designed to be answered slowly, with real detail, not ticked off quickly. If a question doesn't land, say so; that's useful information too.

5

Get your draft, then push back on it

Once all the questions are answered, Claude will draft your statement. Read it out loud. Tell it what doesn't sound like you, and it will revise. You can come back to the same chat any time to keep refining it.

That's genuinely all it takes. No account setup beyond the free sign-up above, no special mode to turn on, nothing to configure. Just a fresh chat, the file, and honest answers. Claude reads the file's instructions and follows them.

Which version to use

GUGGENHEIM-STYLE

`artist-statement-tool-guggenheim.md`

Built directly around the Guggenheim Fellowship's actual two-document structure: a Career Narrative and a Statement of Plans, 1,000 words each. Use this one if you're applying to the Guggenheim specifically, or to any fellowship that asks for a similar pair of documents (a career story plus a concrete plan for a funded period), since it drafts to that shape by default.

GENERAL GRANT

`artist-statement-tool-generic.md`

The same core questions, but before drafting it asks what you're applying for and what that application actually requires, word limits, required sections, a bio, and matches the draft to that instead of assuming a fixed format. Use this one for residencies, open calls, museum applications or any grant that isn't the Guggenheim.

A note on the questions themselves

Both files share the same first stage, and it's the one that matters most: finding the throughline that runs underneath the different things you've made. Everything after that, the career story, the plan, the tone, is easier once that throughline is named. If you only have twenty minutes, spend them there.